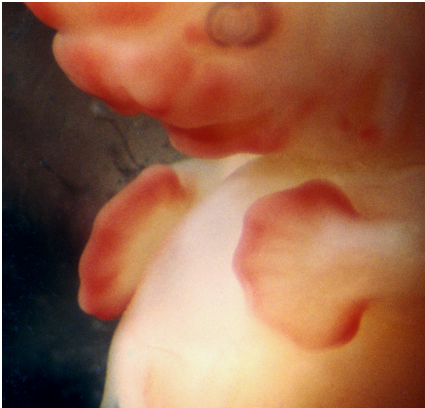




YOU ARE **8 WEEKS AND 4 DAYS**

220 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

In the upper limb bud, the flat expansion that will form the hand can be identified. The fingers are becoming more distinct and there will now be the first signs of movement at the elbows.

“Your baby’s bones are beginning to develop—and they will continue to lengthen from now until the teenage years.”

You won’t be aware of your developing baby’s activities inside the uterus for some months yet, but the fact that their elbows are forming allows them to make some small movements; the wrists do not yet move.

Your baby is looking more human as each day passes. Their vertebrae and ribs are now in place, and their fingers are gradually lengthening. Their body is less curled up than it was a few weeks ago.

The skeleton will gradually calcify and harden. With the exception of the cranial skull bones, all your baby’s bones have a soft cartilage core that will later be reabsorbed as it is converted into hard bone. This process of hardening, known as ossification, starts in so-called primary ossification centers during the next five weeks of your pregnancy. Within these primary centers, specialized cells form spongy then hard bone as calcium salts are laid down. Within the hard bone is red bone marrow, which in later weeks will become the main producer of the baby’s red blood cells.

Secondary ossification centers develop in the second trimester at the ends of each of your baby’s bones.

The portion of bone between the hardening primary and secondary centers is known as the growth plate. This plate is responsible for the continued lengthening of your unborn baby’s bones.

MORE CHEESE PLEASE

There is a lot of confusion about which cheeses are safe to eat in pregnancy. The ones that should be avoided are those made from unpasteurized milk, and those that have a mold-ripened crust, such as Brie, Camembert, or chevre (a soft goat cheese). These could contain a food spoilage organism called *Listeria*. Soft blue cheese such as Roquefort, or Danish Blue, are susceptible to *Listeria* as well.

However, all other cheeses are safe to eat and provide essential protein, calcium, phosphorus, zinc, and vitamin B12. You can enjoy:

- Hard cheeses, such as Cheddar and Parmesan
- Emmental and Swiss